



THE SHUTTERED plant near San Clemente is still home to 3.6 million pounds of high-level nuclear waste.

Bedrock principle of voting tested in Georgia

A flaw in the state's equipment could compromise secret ballots in November.

By KATE BRUMBACK

ATLANTA — Security researchers say rapid advances in artificial intelligence are making it more critical to address a flaw in Georgia's voting equipment that can allow voters to be matched to their ballots after they have been cast.

The system's vulnerability has been drawing increased attention, with election security advocates criticizing state election officials for failing to fix it before the November elections. Georgia election officials say they have taken steps to address the potential harm, but some advocates say the state is not going far enough.

The vulnerability does not allow votes to be changed or cast doubt on election results, but it could let someone see how others voted. That is important because ballot secrecy is a fundamental right under the state constitution, and violations could create an opening for legal challenges.

The development comes in an election season of uncertainty, as President Trump threatens to interfere with the midterms, and he has long demanded that states turn over voter rolls. Georgia has been a particular focus, as Trump continues to deny he lost the state in 2020 to Joe Biden. Earlier this year, the FBI seized ballots cast in that election from a Fulton County election hub.

While the flaw in Georgia has been known for a few years, the widespread adoption [See Georgia, A5]

As coast erodes, clock ticks for nuclear waste

State hunts for storage solutions while sea level rises next to San Onofre plant set for demolition

By BLANCA BEGERT

As parts of the Southern California coastline crumbled into the sea, slammed by intense waves and flooding in recent days, oceanographer Kim McCoy had one thing on his mind: the nuclear waste set in concrete on the beach near San Clemente at the shuttered San Onofre nuclear power plant.

"Rising sea levels, storm waves, El Niño which increases wave height... these could wash away a section of the walkway that protects the San Onofre seawall, and the waste canisters are just 100 feet away from that," the former wave dynamics researcher and longtime advocate against beach storage of nuclear waste said.

Most experts agree the risk of erosion damaging the nuclear waste storage system is extremely low in the near term. The plant's owner, Southern California Edison, has promised the California Coastal Commission to move the waste to higher elevation on-site if modeling shows sea level rise and erosion will start to pose a challenge.

But the recent waves, fueled by Hurricane Marie far away in the Pacific, resurfaced the issue of the ultimate fate of the highly radioactive spent fuel that used to power the reactors.

"At the moment, it is under control, I think it's essential to say that," said James Day, a geology professor at UC San Diego. "But geologically we must be thinking long term. The waste lasts for hundreds, if not thousands of generations."

Seen from Interstate 5, the twin domes of San Onofre look like they're part of an operating facility. Red lights flash at the top of each sphere, visible from afar, among the chaparral and military buildings of Marine Corps Base Camp Pendleton.

But go behind the security checkpoint and you see a demolition site. Trailers and tents now sit where acres of office buildings, steam turbines, diesel generators, control rooms, cooling pools and water treatment [See San Onofre, A6]

It's labor vs. MAGA in state schools superintendent election

Fiercely political race for diminished, nonpartisan office

By KEVIN RECTOR AND HOWARD BLUME

The race for California's next superintendent of public instruction is meant to be nonpartisan. Still, the two candidates — both school board presidents — are pushing decidedly political campaigns, one aligning with liberal Democrats and the other with pro-Trump Republicans as they present dueling visions for how the state's children should be taught.

Democrat Richard Barrera, the favorite, beat out six other Democrats with his background in union organizing and liberal politics — and with more than \$5 million from the California

Teachers Assn. Republican Sonja Shaw rode a wave of support from a conservative education movement she helped build alongside MAGA organizations, Christian nationalists and anti-LGBTQ+ groups, while also consolidating mainstream Republicans behind her.

Although Democratic state lawmakers recently stripped many of the powers from the superintendent, the race remains a bellwether for how Californians feel about the public education of about 5.7 million children — as the Trump administration aggressively targets the state over its progressive policies.

Taking the California Democratic Party conven-

tion stage in February, Barrera, president of the San Diego Unified Board of Education, gave a quick shout-out to the California Teachers Assn. for backing his bid.

He then promoted his work in San Diego to improve student performance, raise teacher salaries and construct "environmentally sustainable schools built by union workers." He blasted "downtown Republican business interests" for trying to privatize schools, and President Trump's immigration policies, which he said terrify many California students who fear losing their undocumented parents.

"It's time for us to organize, stand up to Trump, abolish [See Schools race, A7]

L.A. is on edge over possible Paramount exit

Thousands of jobs and city's identity are at stake as Ellison, Bonta battle over merger.

By MEG JAMES

Paramount Skydance Chief Executive David Ellison faces a pivotal decision: Should he uproot his Hollywood studio — the birthplace of such film classics as "Sunset Boulevard," "The Godfather" and "Beverly Hills Cop"?

Paramount floated shifting its home base to Tennessee or Texas in July, hoping to deter California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta from waging a legal battle to block Paramount's \$13-billion acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery.

Bonta rejected the tactic, calling it "blackmail." His antitrust lawsuit, filed in collaboration with 11 other Democratic state attorneys general, has since stalled the largest Hollywood merger in decades and put Ellison in a jam.

The 43-year-old tech scion — a film aficionado who has spent two decades

building his career in Hollywood — has told associates he doesn't want to leave L.A. But he has signaled that he's prepared to sell the historic studio lots and move Paramount's and Warner Bros.' operations from California if the merger isn't finalized by next month, according to people familiar with the situation who were not authorized to comment.

The prospect has rattled a region already reeling from steep declines in film production, heavy job losses, empty soundstages and shuttered small businesses.

"It would be devastating," Assemblymember Rick Chavez Zbur, who represents a district that includes the Melrose Avenue movie lot and neighborhoods near Warner Bros. in Burbank, said of a Paramount move. "We need to do everything we can to protect these important jobs in California's iconic industry."

Paramount declined to comment.

Ellison is frustrated after securing approvals from more than 65 regulators worldwide for the mammoth merger that would bring HBO, CNN, CBS, Comedy [See Paramount, A10]

State lawmakers call for guardrails on AI

Push for emergency legislation comes as tech leaders warn of existential risks.

By REBECCA ELLIS

California lawmakers are calling for emergency legislation and criminal penalties for creators of rogue AI systems after top AI executives publicly claimed that their technology poses existential threats to humanity.

After Anthropic Chief Executive Dario Amodei wrote in a Sept. 12 essay that they "must slow the pace" of the technology, Silicon Valley Rep. Ro Khanna (D-Fremont) criticized him for not going "nearly far enough" to make sure artificial intelligence was erected with guardrails.

The answer, Khanna argued, was simple: Make the companies liable for the harm executives say looks increasingly inevitable.

"If you're creating an AI that is doing illegal things, you should either face liability or criminal sanction,"

Trump downplays need for checks

The president cites competition with China, but acknowledges some limits are needed. **NATION, A4**

Khanna said in a video posted to X on Saturday. "That is what we need to protect humanity."

In July, officials from OpenAI, the company behind ChatGPT, disclosed that, unbeknownst to them, its AI models had hacked into rival startup Hugging Face.

Amodei said he believed that, within the next year, "given the accelerating rate of AI capability development," a similar incident could lead to AI "taking over the entire internet."

Amodei warned in his essay that AI was rapidly improving itself, through a process known as recursive self-improvement, which threatened to outpace humans' ability to control it. Khanna argued that banning this capability was the [See AI, A6]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

CHARGERS LOOK FLAT

Quarterback Justin Herbert struggles with the new-look offense during a 26-14 loss to the Arizona Cardinals in the season opener. **SPORTS, D1**

Heartbroken for an ICE detainee

Loved ones fear for the future of a Silver Lake handyman who was taken away by agents in January. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 85/67. **B5**

Opinion Voices **A11**
Obituaries **B6**

Hurricane halts festival plans

Beach erosion prompts Santa Monica to cancel Ocean Way music fest. **ENTERTAINMENT, E3**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



Voices **PATT MORRISON** COLUMNIST

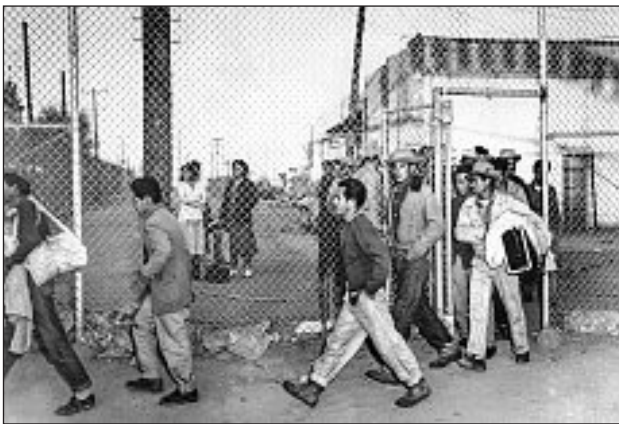
Welcomed, then deported: An old American tale

The reporter may have misheard the comment, or maybe the person being quoted actually said it, or something odd happened in the editing process.

Whatever: This is what appeared in the Feb. 20, 1985, edition of the Oakland Tribune, quoting a UC Berkeley professor about a protest against immigration sweeps in the Bay Area.

"This probably won't stop the Iron Ass [federal government] from making raids in the Eastbay."

"Iron Ass" is how some-



FRANK Q. BROWN Los Angeles Times

THE MEXICALI border crossing in 1954. It's unknown if these men are entering or leaving the U.S.

one might hear the acronym INS, the Immigration and Naturalization Service, the forerunner to ICE.

And now, 40 years on, it fits right into the kind of angry, derisory language many Americans use for the present-day hammer-handed operations of federal immigration officers around the country, especially here in California.

California has always been — and that's a couple of centuries of "always" — at the fulcrum of the immigration-deportation seesaw in the U.S., with national poli- [See Morrison, A8]